

The Vietnam War

In 1955, a conflict began in South Vietnam between communist rebels and the anticommunist government. The US, desperate to stop the spread of communism, supported the South Vietnamese government, and the conflict escalated into a long and bitter war. It ended in 1975, with the defeat of the South Vietnam government.

Vietnam had been split between the communist North Vietnam and the pro-Western South Vietnam in 1954, a year before the conflict began. With support from North Vietnam, communist rebels in the south launched a campaign against the

government aiming to reunite the country under communist rule. Initially, the US sent only military advisors to South Vietnam, but in 1964, following a North Vietnamese attack on a US warship, President Johnson won approval from the US Congress to send in ground troops. The first marines landed in 1965.

Despite heavily bombing in the North, the US was unable to win the war and withdrew all its troops in 1973. Two years later, Vietnam was unified under communist control.



▲ THE TET OFFENSIVE

During the Tet spring festival in 1968, communist forces started a series of attacks on South Vietnamese towns and cities, hoping to trigger an uprising in the country. Although the offensive was beaten back, thousands of soldiers and civilians were killed and the war lost public support in the US.

▼ US INVOLVEMENT IN THE WAR

US military involvement in the war increased from fewer than 1,000 military advisors in 1960 to more than half a million soldiers by the end of the following decade. The US Army used helicopters to transport troops and weapons across Vietnam's jungle terrain.



▲ OPPOSITION TO THE WAR

Opposition to the war in the US grew steadily, particularly among students, and around 50,000 soldiers deserted the armed forces. The killing of four students at a peace rally in 1970 led to massive protests across the nation.

MAJOR EVENTS

1954

After Vietnam wins its freedom from France, the country is divided into two zones—communist-run North Vietnam and anticommunist South Vietnam.

1955

The communist National Liberation Front of South Vietnam, or Viet Cong, starts a rebellion against the South Vietnamese government.

1964

After a naval clash in the Gulf of Tonkin, US President Lyndon B. Johnson massively increases the US military presence in South Vietnam and starts to bomb North Vietnamese cities.

1975

North Vietnam conquers the south following the 1973 Paris Peace Accords and the withdrawal of US forces from Vietnam.